Ready to start?
Create a task in Odin Production Full Workflow.

+ Create task

ON THIS GUIDE 0/27

01 Overview
- Overview
- Expectations
- Payments
- Pay FAQ
- Important Links
- Time Tracking (Insightful)

02 Recording Workflow
- Recording Workflow
- Technical Setup
- Task Ideation
- Studio Workflow
- How to Record Step By Step
- Workflow Checklist

03 Recording Quality Expectations
- Recording Quality Expectations
- Domain Expertise
- Narration Requirements
- Apps and Desktop
- Onscreen Presentation
- PII, Licensed Content, and AI ...

04 Additional Resources
- Additional Resources
- Golden Examples
- “Good” vs “Bad” Task
- Restricted App List
- Common Mistakes

05 Support
- Technical Issues
- FAQ
- Contacts
- Changelog

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

🥇 Golden Examples

odin 🥇 Golden Examples 🥇

Use the Golden Examples to study professional workflow and narration standards.

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1. Finance
2. Design
3. Audio & Music
4. Animation & VFX
5. Software & AI/ML Engineering

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1. Finance

Task Description

I am an Account Receivable personnel at a company in the UK and have been tasked with adding a new vendor to our ERP system and creating a Purchase Order (PO) tracking workflow for our Accounting team to manage POs better. I will begin by adding missing information onto a sample PO on the Pages app, then transfer the vendor details, and PO line items onto our ERP system on Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central, and finally create a PO tracking workflow on Monday.com. I will verify the flow is complete by running the same at the end of its creation and check if the status updates as per the trigger, and deliver the final PO raised on Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central and the PO workflow from Monday.com to my team.

Apps Used

Monday.com

Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central

Pages

Video: Full task recording (44:19)

2. Design

Task Description

I am a Content Creator preparing aspects of a new podcast. Using OBS Studio, I will setup different scenes for different aspects of the podcast such as pre-show and screen-share, which will involve the import of some images. The final deliverables will be the export of the scenes created in OBS.

Apps Used

OBS Studio

Video: Full task recording (24:44)

3. Audio & Music

Task Description

I am a film score composer and I'm working on the underlying theme for a heroic end credit sequence. I will use Logic Pro in the second phase (P2) of the execution to compose a string accompaniment for the piano top melody created in phase one (PI). I will also establish a chordal sequence (I - vi - IV - V) to define the passage. The final deliverable will be a stereo export of the complete Logic Pro session.

Apps Used

Logic Pro

Video: Full task recording (22:58)

4. Animation & VFX

Task Description

You are a 3D Modeler tasked with cleaning up the textures of a photogrammetry model for use in Unreal Engine. Use Adobe Substance 3D Painter to bake the provided high poly model onto the provided low poly model, apply the provided photogrammetry diffuse texture, clean up artifacts on the texture, add a powdery finish to the popcorn and add red and white striped packaging textures to the popcorn box. Export the texture maps appropriate for use in Unreal Engine.

Apps Used

Substance 3D Painter

Video: Full task recording (40:59)

5. Software & AI/ML Engineering

Task Description

As an iOS app developer I want to create a distinctive visual identity for a simple Music Player app. Use SF Symbols as independent visual components, and compose them as separate layers in Icon Composer. Build & refine the multi-layered icon in Icon Composer and integrate the resulting icon into a SwiftUI Music Player app in Xcode. Deliver the layered icon and Xcode project; verify that the app builds successfully and the icon is correctly integrated.

Apps Used

Device Hub

Xcode

SF Symbols

Icon Composer

Video: Full task recording (28:37)

Ready to start?
Create a task in Odin Production Full Workflow.

+ Create task

ON THIS GUIDE 0/27

01 Overview
- Overview
- Expectations
- Payments
- Pay FAQ
- Important Links
- Time Tracking (Insightful)

02 Recording Workflow
- Recording Workflow
- Technical Setup
- Task Ideation
- Studio Workflow
- How to Record Step By Step
- Workflow Checklist

03 Recording Quality Expectations
- Recording Quality Expectations
- Domain Expertise
- Narration Requirements
- Apps and Desktop
- Onscreen Presentation
- PII, Licensed Content, and AI ...

04 Additional Resources
- Additional Resources
- Golden Examples
- “Good” vs “Bad” Task
- Restricted App List
- Common Mistakes

05 Support
- Technical Issues
- FAQ
- Contacts
- Changelog

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

🚦 “Good” vs “Bad” Task

Good vs. Bad Task

Below are key points of a good TaskRecorder task and what to avoid. Use the Golden Examples to study professional workflow and narration.

PROJECT
Odin · GOOD VS. BAD TASK

	Bad Task	Good Task
Task Description	• Task description (Goal) is too vague to explain the task, apps, or intended result.	• Get your idea approved. Use only the Goal in TaskRecorder and the opening doc. • Task description (Goal) document is not a restricted app.
Intro	• The recording does not show the Task Description (Goal) briefly at the start, followed by minimizing it. • Introduction narration is long and descriptive rather than saying the provided introduction sentence. • The introduction does **not** include narration, only an app with the written Task Description (Goal). • Recording starts after important actions for the task are completed • The recording includes preparation that belongs before the task, such as drafting the Task Description (Goal), loading apps, or changing the desktop setup.	• TR is *minimized immediately* after the recording starts. • Setup takes place *before* the recording. • Narrates a concise introduction • Recording starts with apps open (dot under the app in the dock) and Task Description (Goal) shown • Task Description (Goal) document is *minimized or closed a few seconds after the introduction has concluded* .
UI Diversity	• No change in any of the UI elements • Dock at the bottom of the screen • Menu bar clock does not show seconds	• Change at least one UI element per recording; more is better: wallpaper, light or dark mode, accent color, Dock size, sidebar icon size, screen resolution, or an in-app theme. • Dock at the left or right of the screen • Menu bar clock shows seconds
Screen Discipline	• Scrolls past relevant content repeatedly without acting • Overlapping or obscured working windows need a qualitative delivery callout, not a numeric grade or standalone rejection. • **Windows are stacked on top of each other**, fully covering background apps • A small floating window makes the content hard to see and leaves most of the desktop unused.	• Environment set up intentionally before starting • Organized workspace maintained throughout • Only windows relevant to the current task/sub-task remain visible; all others minimized • Use one clear ordinary window or place needed windows side by side. Temporary pop-ups or dialogs within the same app may overlap while you use them. • Full-screen (clock and dock not visible) is **not** used
Cursor & Mouse	• Constant aimless circles or jitter, no task intent • Frequently uses keyboard shortcuts where mouse actions were expected • Use the cursor naturally as a teaching pointer, without artificial movement. Mouse inactivity needs a qualitative delivery callout, not a numeric grade. The closing epilogue may be still.	• Deliberate, goes only where attention is • Use the cursor as a teaching pointer so viewers can follow your reasoning.

Pacing & Presence	• Experts rush through steps • Uneven pacing; idle periods present but task moves forward • Duration padded with unnecessary actions	• Well-paced start to finish; every segment has task value • Work naturally, explain your decisions and avoid unnecessary waiting. • Experts wait 1s beat before clicking the next item
Workflow Adherence	• No clear task goal or planned workflow. • Abandoned within 30 sec, no meaningful attempt • **Restricted app used** • No coherent workflow; unrelated activity begins • The stated task goal is not completed. • Less than half of the intended workflow completed • Tasks substantially repeat the same workflow; changing only the topic or wording does not make it different. • None of the client required apps is used in the task (if applicable) • Majority completed; one major step skipped or weak • Coding and Content & Writing tasks: up to 35% of the recording may be typing. • All other tasks: up to 25% of the recording may be typing. • For every task, no continuous typing segment longer than 45 seconds. Mouse inactivity is handled separately as a qualitative delivery callout; the closing epilogue may be still. • Extra apps are added only to increase the count, without contributing meaningful work. Single-app tasks are acceptable when they meet the same quality and expertise standards. • Metadata file is shown in the recording	• At least one client required app is used in the task (if applicable) • Keep the work mouse-driven. Treat 35% typing for Coding + Content & Writing tasks and 25% for other tasks as ceilings, not targets. Typing fails only above the applicable ceiling; equality does not fail. • Complete the planned workflow and produce a clear, useful final deliverable. • Explain your choices and the professional reasons behind them. • Use each app naturally and give it a clear purpose in the task or final output. • Metadata file is NOT shown in the recording
Completion	• Recording incomplete or missing • Deliverables not saved • Output present but too thin or generic to be usable • Continues tinkering after task done, ambiguous endpoint	• Output is reviewed before stopping; clear wrap-up • Add further work only when it genuinely improves the promised result in a relevant direction • Prior feedback fully addressed • Include every input, intermediate artifact and final output in Deliverables.zip, using the required labels and file extensions.
Accuracy and Error Recovery	• Multiple significant errors, no self-correction • Notices error but doesn't fully resolve it • Corrects mistake but doesn't verify the fix	• No material error occurs, or any error is promptly diagnosed, corrected and verified without disrupting the workflow • Final output is carefully reviewed
Domain & Tool Expertise	• Basic, generic work that someone without your domain expertise could do. • Basic work that does not require domain knowledge combined with surface level app tool use • Meanders through menus with no progress visible • Learns the software by trial and error during recording	• Use professional methods and app features you already know. Explain important choices and anticipate relevant edge cases.
Narration & Audio	• No narration, or audio absent/unintelligible • Narration contradicts what's on screen • Gap >45 sec, speaking the Task Description (Goal), or profanity • Long stretches unnarrated; major steps happen in silence • Rambling or filler that doesn't track the workflow • Narrates some steps but skips others; intermittent gaps • Explains what but not why, even for important or non-obvious decisions • Occasional shortcuts not called out • Background noise obscures over 40% of the narration. Noise obscuring 30-40% receives nonblocking feedback; aim for clear audio.	• Narrate throughout, as if teaching someone how to do the task. • Name what you are doing and where you are doing it, using specific control and location names. • The cursor is positioned over the item being referred to in the narration. • Explain your reasoning and small professional decisions as they happen. • Clean synchronised audio; concise, no rambling; no background noise
Written Quality	• Writing errors affect the meaning or make the final output unusable.	• Use accurate, professional writing and clean formatting. Minor errors are acceptable only if they do not affect the meaning or core result.

Previous

Next

Ready to start?
Create a task in Odin Production Full Workflow.

+ Create task

ON THIS GUIDE 0/27

01 Overview
- Overview
- Expectations
- Payments
- Pay FAQ
- Important Links
- Time Tracking (Insightful)

02 Recording Workflow
- Recording Workflow
- Technical Setup
- Task Ideation
- Studio Workflow
- How to Record Step By Step
- Workflow Checklist

03 Recording Quality Expectations
- Recording Quality Expectations
- Domain Expertise
- Narration Requirements
- Apps and Desktop
- Onscreen Presentation
- PII, Licensed Content, and AI ...

04 Additional Resources
- Additional Resources
- Golden Examples
- “Good” vs “Bad” Task
- Restricted App List
- Common Mistakes

05 Support
- Technical Issues
- FAQ
- Contacts
- Changelog

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

❌ Restricted App List

App Eligibility and Limited Use

Effective for new work started on or after 2026-10-16 18:08 PDT.

The approved-app requirement is retired. Unrestricted apps may be used without prior approval, including apps absent from the catalog. Use these three categories and the canonical restricted-app and limited-use rules when older Studio labels or copied lists disagree.

Canonical app list: https://odin-mercor1.vercel.app/validated-apps

Work already underway before the cutoff is protected from newly applied app restrictions. Do not discard, restart or reject that work solely because of this update. Other quality checks still apply.

Previously rejected ideas or tasks involving an app that is now allowed may be reconsidered, subject to all other applicable quality checks.

Existing licensing, account, AI-use, opening-Goal and task-quality requirements still apply. Payment terms are unchanged.

Chrome and Safari are permitted.

We're seeing a lot of recording issues when writers use Excel with TaskRecorder. To avoid problems with your recordings, we recommend using an alternative like Google Sheets.

Banned for new work

- Godot
- VSCodium
- Inkscape
- GIMP
- Blender
- MATLAB
- Sublime Text
- Photoshop
- Ableton Live / Live
- ZBrush
- Grammarly
- Microsoft Whiteboard
- Adobe Bridge
- Adobe Animate
- Unreal Editor
- Telegram
- KNIME
- Reactotron
- Craft
- LiquidText

- Media Encoder
- Sublime Merge
- Vital
- Twinmotion
- KNIME Analytics Platform
- Figma
- Adobe Lightroom
- Autodesk FBX Review
- Defold
- KiCad
- OpenVSP
- anatomyapp
- FL Studio / FruitLoops Studio
- GameMaker
- LTspice
- Parallels Desktop
- UCSF Chimera
- VMD
- Wolfram Mathematica
- Substance 3D Stager
- Sticky Notepad
- Penpot
- MohrPlotter
- JASP
- TextExpander
- TextEdit: **permitted only for creating metadata.rtf.**

Allowed for minimal use

Project operating rule: minimal use means less than 20% of the task. Workpuls/Insightful and Splashtop Streamer remain background-only, and app-specific supporting-use limits still apply.

- iTerm: minimal use only.
- Workpuls / Insightful: background or toolbar only; do not actively use it or show its window during recording.
- Splashtop Streamer: background only; do not actively use it during the task.
- RecipeKeeper: only when needed for minimal supporting use; do not use as the main application.
- drawBook: only when needed for minimal supporting use; do not use as the main application.
- Milanote: only when needed for minimal supporting use; do not use as the main application.

Allowed, but prefer alternatives when practical

- Excel
- Preview
- LibreOffice
- Freeform
- Stickies
- Calendar
- Terminal

- Canva
- Numbers
- Reminders
- Simplenote

Before recording

Check the current app status and use apps that contribute meaningfully to the task. Safari, Chrome and Firefox are allowed.

Apps absent from the restricted list need no separate app approval. Follow the current app categories and usage conditions, and record only after the idea is approved. Licensing and all other quality checks still apply.

Ready to start?
Create a task in Odin Production Full Workflow.

+ Create task

ON THIS GUIDE 0/27

01 Overview
- Overview
- Expectations
- Payments
- Pay FAQ
- Important Links
- Time Tracking (Insightful)

02 Recording Workflow
- Recording Workflow
- Technical Setup
- Task Ideation
- Studio Workflow
- How to Record Step By Step
- Workflow Checklist

03 Recording Quality Expectations
- Recording Quality Expectations
- Domain Expertise
- Narration Requirements
- Apps and Desktop
- Onscreen Presentation
- PII, Licensed Content, and AI ...

04 Additional Resources
- Additional Resources
- Golden Examples
- “Good” vs “Bad” Task
- Restricted App List
- Common Mistakes

05 Support
- Technical Issues
- FAQ
- Contacts
- Changelog

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

❌ Common Mistakes

Common Mistakes

Rejection Item	Explanation
Task Description	Use the friend-with-no-domain-expertise test to choose a task that uses your skills. The Task Description (Goal) should briefly explain your role, the apps and key methods, and the intended result; it does not need to fill a page.
Task Recorder Version	You must use the current version of Task Recorder and not an older one from past phases.
Frame loss (TR)	Missing PNGs or low PNG count (<0.5 per second of recording). We must have all the data required for the client.
Restricted app	Do not use an app on the banned list at https://odin-mercor1.vercel.app/validated-apps, including by entering it under Other in Studio. Ignore stale 'restricted' labels in Studio; Word, PowerPoint, Premiere Pro and Illustrator are allowed.
UI Diversity	Each recording must change at least one UI element (wallpaper, light or dark mode, accent color, Dock size, sidebar icon size, screen resolution, or an in-app theme); more is better.
Dock	Dock should be on the left or right and not minimized. Dock should **not** be at the bottom of the screen.
Menu bar clock	Seconds must be displayed on the menu bar clock.
No Setup/Introduction	Task description (Goal) document must be displayed at the beginning of the video and intro narration should not last longer than 20 seconds.
Accessibility Inspector	Accessibility Inspector not running during the video.
Task length	Total video length: Plan recording length, including the short intro and epilogue, to be at least 15 minutes and no more than 50:59 minutes (15:00-50:59).
Narration below the target	Narration does not clearly describe What and Where for each meaningful step.
Profanity	Profanity must not be in narration or shown in recording
Silence gap	A single audio silence gap over 60 seconds fails. Gaps of 46-60 seconds receive nonblocking feedback; aim for gaps of 45 seconds or less.
AI usage	Any generative AI in video. **Only ordinary built-in functionality not presented as AI is permitted; do not prompt, converse, generate or summarize task content with AI during recording.** AI may prepare inputs before recording. At first use, explain the prepared file's contents, purpose and CC0 or public domain status without naming an AI tool or inventing a source. Put “AI-generated before recording” in Studio Final Notes.
PII	Private or non-public personal information must not be visible or audible. Examples of exceptions are public GitHub user information/emails and author information/emails in public research papers; these do not permit unrelated private information.
Project references	Keep Mercor, Project Odin, Studio and other project materials out of view. TaskRecorder may appear only for the required Start Recording and Stop Recording actions; minimize it immediately after starting.
Copyright	Do not use paywalled, watermarked, Unsplash or unclear-rights content. Check the original source for CC0/public-domain or equivalent permission and terms permitting AI-training use; a search filter alone is not sufficient.

Input files (if applicable)	Include all input files in Deliverables.zip. In Studio Final Notes, provide each non-AI source URL or exactly “AI-generated before recording” for AI-created inputs; complete Source of Data when applicable as well.
Window Management	Keep working windows readable and minimize unused overlaps. Window-management issues are recorded as qualitative delivery callouts with useful timestamps; they are not graded and do not cause rejection or rerecording on their own.
Mouse inactivity	Use the cursor naturally as a teaching pointer. Mouse inactivity is recorded as a qualitative delivery callout with useful timestamps; it is not graded and does not cause rejection or rerecording on its own. The closing epilogue may be still. Keep the separate continuous-typing limit.
Excessive typing	Typing should not take up too much of video length
Deliverable File missing from the .zip	The deliverable must contain a final output file in the Deliverables.zip. If input files, intermediate artifacts, or multiple final outputs exist in the task, all of them must be present in the Deliverables.zip.
Metadata visibility	Metadata.rtf window should not be shown in the recording
Workpuls/Insightful	Workpuls/Insightful window can not be opened in the recording (it is allowed minimized in the Dock)

← Previous

Next →